

Sanborn Fire Insurance Maps

Surprisingly Useful to Many

Started in 1867 to help establish fire insurance rates, the Sanborn Map Company created detailed maps of burgeoning towns and cities, updating them every few years. The maps included a wealth of information such as type of construction and business, size and number of stories of buildings, the presence of fire-fighting resources, and even prevailing winds. Today these maps find multiple uses in many professions and avocations.



Preservationists

identify construction materials and methods to accurately renovate and emulate historical buildings.

Environmentalists

trace hazardous waste sites back to original polluters, locate decaying underground tanks, and take note of natural features erased long ago.

Urban planners

decipher the intended and accidental layouts of urban living, drawing on successive mappings of urban sprawl.

Geoscientists

use construction data with historical pictorial damage reports to identify spatial variations in shaking intensity of past earthquakes.

Genealogists

find churches to locate records, cemeteries to find family graves, county boundary movement to search for appropriate government records.

Other users

include demographers to chart population shifts, economists to study the development and movement of commerce, archeologists to pinpoint sites of demolished buildings.